

“I am the strength of the world ... I am the one who knows how to fly.”

PART OF A TRADITIONAL-STYLE AZTEC RITUAL CHANT

The Aztecs believed in magical afflictions sent by the *tlacatecolotl*, and hallucinogens such as peyotl might be taken by cursed people to help *ticitl* identify the curse.

Sorcery or satanism?

One famed figure from Aztec myth is the *tlahuipuchtli* (luminous sorceress) Malinalxochitl, who was widely believed to inflict unpleasant deaths on

her enemies. Today people from the Mexican town of Malinalco, which was allegedly founded by her, still carry the reputation of being magicians.

To the Aztecs, ritual sacrifice of humans and animals was a vital and honorable part of pleasing the gods. Yet colonizers considered it a satanic and barbaric practice. As the European view came to dominate, the meaning and cultural context of the practice were often overlooked or misunderstood.

▼ Revered rituals

This image from the *Tovar Codex* depicts three priests making ritual offerings to prevent drought. The first priest (far left) bears burning incense in the form of a tree resin called copal, which was often used in Aztec ceremonies.

